

Emily Brontë's Wuthering Heights [B2]

Quando fu pubblicato, il romanzo di Emily Brontë scandalizzò pubblico e critica. Oggi, è l'audace adattamento cinematografica di Emerald Fennell a far discutere.

Emily Brontë (1818-1848) spent most of her short life in the village of Haworth in northern England, surrounded by [moorland](#). Though she wrote stories and poems from a young age with her [siblings](#), Wuthering Heights is her only novel. It was published (initially under the male pseudonym Ellis Bell) in December 1847 when Brontë was twenty-nine. She died very soon afterwards of tuberculosis, just three months after the death of her brother Branwell.

PRIMAL PASSION

At the centre of the story are Cathy and her adopted brother Heathcliff, who grow up on the moors in an isolated house called Wuthering Heights. 'Wuthering' is an old Yorkshire dialect term meaning 'windy'. As teenagers, Cathy and Heathcliff's feelings for each other become intense and passionate, perhaps even obsessive. They spend their days together out on the moors, partly to get away from Cathy's older brother Hindley, who is cruel and violent towards Heathcliff. The wild landscape adds a primal energy to their relationship. But then Cathy [gets engaged](#) to the wealthy Edgar Linton of Thrushcross Grange for the money and status he can offer her. Heathcliff, devastated, disappears, promising to take revenge. Despite being married to Edgar, Cathy's heart remains chained to Heathcliff's. When Heathcliff returns to Wuthering Heights some years later, having made his fortune, the passion between him and Cathy intensifies, but the relationship cannot be. Cathy dies in [childbirth](#), pregnant with Linton's daughter, also named Cathy. Heathcliff, [haunted](#) by her presence, [unleashes](#) cruelty and revenge on the next generation.

A MASTERPIECE

The novel spans several generations and has a complex structure using flashbacks and multiple narrators. In fact, it tells the end of the story first, starting with a diary entry written by a character called Lockwood in 1801. Lockwood describes getting lost on the moors in a storm and knocking at the door of Wuthering Heights to ask for shelter. He is shocked by the gothic scene inside. The master of the house is Heathcliff, who is about forty by this time. He is rude and aggressive and appears to terrorise the two young people who live there with him. We find out that they are Cathy's daughter and Hindley's son. Lockwood sleeps at Wuthering Heights but in the middle of the night is woken by Cathy's ghost trying to get in through a broken window. Horrified by what he has seen, Lockwood asks Nelly Dean, the housekeeper who has known Cathy and Heathcliff since childhood, to tell him more about them. At this point, the narration shifts from Lockwood's voice to Nelly's and we go back to the beginning of the story, when the father of Cathy and Hindley brings home an orphan boy. This orphan is Heathcliff. Culture

Literary Icons: The Brontë Sisters Come Emily, le sorelle Charlotte e Anne si spinsero fino ai confini della psicologia umana, con personaggi femminili complessi. Nei loro scritti risaltano la passione e gli sforzi per superare le restrizioni dell'ambiente sociale. Daniel Francis , Sarah Presant Collins

TIME AND PLACE

There have been several high-profile film adaptations of Wuthering Heights over the years. Most film versions focus on the passionate relationship between Cathy and Heathcliff, cutting out the story around the second generation. The wild moors provide a dramatic setting for many of the films. But some directors reimagine the action elsewhere. For example, in *Hurlevent* (1985), a French-language adaptation directed by Jacques Rivette, the action is relocated to 1930s southern France. For his famous Spanish-language version, *Abismos de pasión*, Luis Buñuel sets the book in 19th-century Mexico. There are also adaptations in Hindi, Urdu, and Filipino.

CHANGING THE LOOK

Emily Brontë's story has a power that transcends time and place, and different directors have chosen different aesthetics for telling the tale. In William Wyler's 1939 black-and-white film, Heathcliff and Cathy are [framed](#) as typical Hollywood lovers. Peter Kosminsky's 1992 version reflects the decade's taste for [period drama](#) with elaborate period [costumes](#) and interiors. Andrea Arnold's 2011 version, by contrast, uses a simple, [earthy](#) aesthetic, and some scenes have the informal, intimate look of mobile phone [footage](#). Emerald Fennell's adaptation, set to be released in time for Valentine's Day this year, has chosen an extravagant, hyper-sexualised approach, one that some critics believe goes too far. There are [blatantly](#) anachronistic costume choices: Cathy in red John Lennon sunglasses, for example. And there is some graphic sexual content: the opening scene involves a public execution in which the hanged man has an erection, and there are also scenes of masturbation and sadomasochism.

STILL SHOCKING

Some viewers may not like Fennell's graphic scenes of sex and violence, but it's worth remembering that Emily Brontë's novel was criticised for similar reasons back in 1847. While some of her Victorian critics [praised](#) the power of *Wuthering Heights*, others were [appalled](#) at what they saw as the book's depravity. *Atlas* magazine published a critical review in January 1848 stating that the novel "presents such shocking pictures of the worst forms of humanity." Another newspaper from the same month published a generally favourable review but still noted that: "The reader is shocked, [disgusted](#), almost [sickened](#) by details of cruelty, inhumanity, and the most diabolical hate and vengeance." Nearly two hundred years on, Brontë's work, reinterpreted for a modern audience, still has the power to captivate and shock. If you want to know more about this topic, read the articles [Emerald Fennell: The Greatest Love Story of All Time](#) and [Top 5 Wuthering Heights Adaptations](#).

Glossary

- **moorland** = brughiera
- **siblings** = sorelle e fratelli
- **gets engaged** = fidanzarsi
- **unleashes** = scatenare
- **rude** = maleducato, sgarbato
- **blatantly** = sfacciatamente
- **praised** = lodare
- **disgusted** = disgustare
- **childbirth** = parto
- **haunted** = tormentato, perseguitato
- **spans** = abbracciare
- **housekeeper** = governante
- **footage** = filmato, riprese
- **appalled** = inorriditi
- **sickened** = nauseare
- **earthy** = rustica, semplice
- **costumes** = costumi
- **shelter** = rifugio
- **shifts** = cambiare
- **framed** = rappresentare
- **period drama** = dramma in costume